

COLD CALLS

What one call looks like, side to side

BUREAU OF AMBIENT BELONGING
SAM REMIX 2026

Two strangers pick up handsets on opposite sides of an easel. Either side can be the caller – whoever lifts first becomes Side A for that call. The roles are not fixed to a physical side.

SIDE A the caller		SIDE B the receiver
BEFORE THE CALL		
idle	on hook, silent	on hook, silent
SOMEONE PICKS UP		
0:00	LIFTS THE HANDSET hears: dial tone	on hook hears: nothing
0:02	dial tone cuts off hears: touch-tone dialing dials a random famous number – Jenny's 867-5309, and friends	hears: nothing
RINGING		
0:04	hears: ringback, looping brrr-brrr ... brrr-brrr waits up to 30 seconds	>>> THE PRINTER BUZZES one buzz every 2 seconds The handset does not ring. The receipt printer is the bell – it is what recruits a stranger who has not opted in yet.
0:10	ringback stops	LIFTS THE HANDSET
BOTH HANDSETS UP – THE QUIET MOMENT		
0:10	hears: nothing the receipt prints a prompt from this side's department	hears: nothing the receipt prints a different prompt, from the other department
Both printers run before any audio starts. Takes 5-15 seconds, and it is silent on both ends. This gap either reads as anticipation or as “this thing is broken” – which one depends on whether the paper is visibly moving where they can see it.		
THE OPERATOR		
0:18	hears: “One moment please, your call is being connected.”	hears, the same moment: “One moment please, your call is being connected.”
CONNECTED		
0:22	voice -----> <----- earpiece rain / city ambience mixed softly underneath	<----- earpiece voice -----> rain / city ambience mixed softly underneath
They talk. They read each other their prompts. They answer with stamps, stickers, and tape on the easel between them – no pens. It runs as long as they both stay on the handset. There is no time limit.		
EITHER SIDE HANGS UP		
–	HANGS UP or the other side does – it works the same either way	still holding the handset hears: a click, then a busy tone, looping until they hang up too
+1s	both on hook – ready for the next pair	both on hook – ready for the next pair
IF NOBODY ANSWERS		
0:04	hears: ringback, 30 seconds	printer buzzing, unanswered
0:34	hears: “We're sorry. The number you have dialed is not in service. Please hang up and try again.”	still on hook
0:40	click, then busy tone until they hang up	–

Timings from src/cold_call/session.py. Conversation length is unbounded; all other durations are fixed.